The Canadian Journal for the Scholarship of Teaching and Learning

Volume 17 | Issue 1 Article 12

Spring 04-30-2026

From Anxiety to Engagement: Transforming Social Work Research Education

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https://doi.org/10.5206/cjsotlrcacea.2026.1.18958

Recommended Citation
Rao, S., & Lee, Y. (2026). From anxiety to engagement: Transforming social work research education. *The Canadian Journal for the Scholarship of Teaching and Learning, 17*(1). https://doi.org/10.5206/cjsotlrcacea.2026.1.18958

From Anxiety to Engagement: Transforming Social Work Research Education

Abstract
In this study, we explore the transformation of social work students from experiencing research anxiety to active engagement in research conducted within a mandatory course at a leading Canadian university. Traditionally, many social workers have perceived a distinct divide between practical social work and academic research, often viewing research methodologies as intimidating and unrelated to their professional responsibilities. The course was reformatted to help students view research as integral to effective social work and consider themselves as potential researchers. Grounded in critical pedagogy, disability justice, trauma-informed education, and anti-oppressive frameworks, this manuscript draws from detailed reflections on teaching strategies and extensive student feedback to propose ten principles aimed at fostering research-informed competencies among social work undergraduate students. These principles are designed to cultivate curiosity, mastery, and enjoyment in research, making this approach beneficial to social work students and anyone experiencing educational anxiety or resistance. This manuscript underscores the importance of transforming educational strategies to help students develop competencies that enhance their professional abilities and personal confidence in tackling new and challenging learning areas.

Dans cette étude, nous explorons la transformation des étudiants et des étudiantes en travail social, qui sont passés d'une anxiété face à la recherche à une participation active à des travaux de recherche menés dans le cadre d'un cours obligatoire dans une université canadienne de premier plan. Traditionnellement, de nombreuses personnes qui pratiquent le travail social ont perçu un fossé distinct entre le travail social pratique et la recherche universitaire, considérant souvent les méthodologies de recherche comme intimidantes et sans rapport avec leurs responsabilités professionnelles. Le cours a été remanié afin d'aider les étudiants et les étudiantes à considérer la recherche comme faisant partie intégrante d'un travail social efficace et à se considérer eux-mêmes comme des chercheurs potentiels. S'appuyant sur la pédagogie critique, la justice pour les personnes handicapées, l'éducation tenant compte des traumatismes et les cadres anti-oppressifs, ce manuscrit s'inspire de réflexions détaillées sur les stratégies d'enseignement et des commentaires approfondis des étudiants et des étudiantes pour proposer dix principes visant à favoriser les compétences fondées sur la recherche chez les étudiants et les étudiantes de premier cycle en travail social. Ces principes sont conçus pour cultiver la curiosité, la maîtrise et le plaisir de la recherche, rendant cette approche bénéfique pour les étudiants et les étudiantes en travail social et toute personne souffrant d'anxiété ou de résistance à l'égard de l'éducation. Ce manuscrit souligne l'importance de transformer les stratégies éducatives afin d'aider les étudiants et les étudiantes à développer des compétences qui renforcent leurs capacités professionnelles et leur confiance personnelle pour aborder des domaines d'apprentissage nouveaux et difficiles.

Keywords
social work education, trauma-informed education, social work research, pedagogy; formation en travail social, éducation tenant compte des traumatismes, recherche en travail social, pédagogie

This research paper/Rapport de recherche is available in The Canadian Journal for the Scholarship of Teaching and Learning: https://doi.org/10.5206/cjsotlrcacea.2026.1.18958

"I was not 'research resistant' at the beginning of this course, but I did have reservations how research would fit into a social work perspective. I am happy to share that this course has surpassed my expectations and broadened my research framework (I had to shift from a positivist approach to be more open to embrace qualitative methods). Now, I am much more interested and engaged with qualitative research. I am excited to incorporate photovoice and other multisensory approaches to learn about people's experiences. I am very interested in community-based research as well." **[Social Work Undergraduate Student]**

There is a decades-long (Epstein, 1987), well-documented concern (Bolin et al., 2012; Cameron & Este, 2008; Einbinder, 2014; Flynn & McDermott, 2017) regarding the uptake of research by social work students, specifically challenges in understanding the value of research for practice. This was reinforced by our students, as 88.89% of students stated they did not feel comfortable with research, elaborating in their course feedback, "many of my classmates were anxious about this course," "I was very anxious about this class as research can be a difficult topic," and, "my past experience with research classes had been very stressful."

We are critical of the approach to the debate, as it has been undermined by two assumptions: 1) the world of practitioner and that of researcher are separate (Newman & McNamara, 2016), and, 2) that "research" is the continuance of the positivist "scientific" agenda (Epstein, 1987; Gibbs and Stirling, 2010; Newman and McNamara, 2016). We believe it is necessary to shift the dialogue from dichotomized debates to facilitate discussions on the need for social work research—specifically qualitative research, assisted and reinforced by social work practices and practice experience.

Before the class began officially, we discussed our past experiences, both in class as instructors and as colleagues to other students. We posited that the variation in student attitudes we have witnessed—including tears, anger, anxiety, panic attacks, and, in some cases, withdrawal from research courses arises from preconceived positivist perspectives of research. These included global concerns about "being bad at math" or "not good at science," which is mirrored across the social work education literature (Einbinder, 2014; Harder, 2010; Powell & Orme, 2011, 2011).

Smith (1987) writes about the success of positivism in winning acceptance for its assumptions among lay people and stresses that social work students are not exempt from the belief of positivism as the penultimate all-encompassing "research." To address these challenges, we felt it was imperative to reassess and enhance the manner in which social work research is taught. Introducing qualitative methodologies and innovative critical methods, such as feminist approaches, community-based research, and participant-action research, would broaden the research landscape for social work students. The transformative potential of these methodologies acknowledges the complexities of social work and can significantly enrich students' educational experiences. By guiding students through the initial challenges of engaging with research, free from the constraints of a solely positivist framework, we could cultivate a more inclusive and effective research curriculum that aligns more closely with the dynamic needs of social work practice.

Context and Locatedness

This article provides reflections on a Fall 2021 research course that took place at a large university in Western Canada, rated as one of the top five research universities nationally (Re$earch Infosource Inc., 2021). This specific research course is the only mandatory research

course to complete the Bachelor of Social Work degree. It is our intention to highlight challenges identified by our students, their needs, and how we might help students overcome their fears and reluctance to *cultivate curiosity*, *mastery* and, drawing from the work of Epstein (1987), *joy*.

Positionality

We are two social work women of colour who are quite fond of research and practice. We include this fact as Powell & Orme (2011) found it was often social work educators that *also* had fears and concerns about research and teaching of research that impacted the views of students. We hope that our reflections evolve the discourse for incoming social work students on what research is, does, and means; and that the old guard of positivism will lose its pervasive nature in the hearts and minds of incoming students. We also draw from Galiè and Farnworth (2019) our conceptualization of empowerment, which involves embracing *power with*, which emphasizes collaboration and collective decision-making; *power within*, recognizing each student's intrinsic capability and personal agency; *power to*, acknowledging each student's ability to effect change; and *power through*, highlighting the synergy of collaborative efforts.

Social Work Students

Considering the diversity of our classroom, we took an intersectional lens to address questions that have prevented us from looking more broadly at the issues that social work students face in their educational experiences. Collins and Bilge (2016) remind us that intersectionality provides a way of analyzing the complexity in the world, in people, and in human experiences:

> People's lives and the organization of power in a given society are better understood as being shaped not by a single axis of social division, be it race or gender or class, but by many axes that work together and influence each other (Collins & Bilge, 2016, p. 2).

This definition is particularly helpful as it clarifies that intersectionality is not just about an individual's identity but also about the framing of social and political conditions that influence power and inequality.

While many authors have asserted that students have negative attitudes toward or are reluctant to take research or statistics courses (Newman & McNamara, 2016; Powell & Orme, 2011; D. Smith, 1987; Unrau & Grinnell, 2005), this reluctance is more prevalent among students of colour and women, who constitute the majority of social work students (Davis, 2003; Onwuegbuzie, 2004). The reluctance of women is not surprising in light of the persistence of negative stereotypes about women's aptitude for research (Davis, 2003).

It is also important to appreciate that rates of previous trauma exposure are likely to be higher among social work students than the general population (Butler et al., 2017; Gilin & Kauffman, 2015), with subpopulations such as, racialized, individuals with low income and sexually diverse individuals at even greater risk of exposure to trauma, secondary trauma and training-related retraumatization (Merrick et al., 2018). Such matters have been exacerbated by the COVID-19 pandemic where institutions, such as universities, often perpetuate systems of oppression for individuals from minoritized backgrounds (Sotto-Santiago, 2019), resulting in further discrimination and obtaining poorer educational and vocational outcomes (Kantamneni, 2020). All this to say, despite high rates of early and continuing adversity among social work

students, their arrival at higher-level education is a testament to their capacity and tenacity (Sanders, 2021).

Big "R" to small "r"

Much of the literature calls for social workers to become research-minded or research literate. What it fails to consider is the continuance of the positivist "scientific" agenda with its immutability and longevity in the research milieu. Newman & McNamara (2016) report on the "quantocentric culture" in social work education and practice, as social work research has been critiqued for accepting dominant methodologies, which lack its liberating, emancipatory values, central to social work practice (Haight & Bidwell, 2016).

Hardcastle and Bisman (2003) argue that embracing feminist, heuristic, and grassroots ideologies can fundamentally alter the research landscape. This shift underscores that the creation of social work knowledge should not be confined to a small group within academia but rather should be a widespread responsibility shared across all levels of the profession, including both academic and practice settings.

The concept of a research continuum, as described by Lewis (2003), ranges from 'Big R' research—comprehensive, well-funded studies typically conducted within academic or institutional settings—to 'small r' research, which encompasses less formal, often unfunded inquiries that are equally critical to the field. The research conducted for this study is precisely an example of 'small r' research, as it focuses on classroom-based innovations aimed at transforming students' engagement with research. This study clearly demonstrates the value of 'small r' research in social work education, as it provides direct, practice-based insights that shape pedagogical approaches and improve student experiences.

We believe growing research capacity must be based in nurturing curiosity of social workers, such that they can channel their curiosity through engagement in research—big 'R' and small 'r', activities. Education then, must be inclusive to include practitioners who wish to develop academically, not *just* in terms of their practice. Instead, research is seen as integral to social work as a profession as well as to the discipline.

Sparking Joy: Social Work Praxis

Some authors have suggested that social work and social work research have complementary values, principles and processes (Newman & McNamara, 2016). We take this a step further to propose they are two sides of the same coin. This is best summed up in the idea of praxis. Freire (2000) described praxis as "reflection and action upon the world in order to transform it" (p.52). This combination of reflection and action is at the heart of praxis. For example, in adult education Zuber-Skerritt (2001) defines praxis as the interdependence and integration of theory and practice, research and development, thought and action. In other words, "praxis involves knowing, doing and being" (White, 2007, p.226).

Youll and Walker (1995) argue that advanced social work practice requires the reflection, systematic review and critical analysis used in the development of responsive and innovative services' which resonates with participatory and action research. These approaches are aligned to social work principles and have clear links with service user movements, with a commitment to participate with people in improving and understanding the world by changing it (Bergold & Thomas, 2012; Borda, 2006; Giannakaki et al., 2018; Shimmin et al., 2017).

Thus, research—in the broadest sense, the way we understand things, is embedded in reflection and action; and action is embedded in reflection and theory. They cannot be separated, they are inextricably linked. Five assumptions about knowledge and knowing that would closely align with social work praxis can be drawn from White (2007): "1) knowledge/knowing is inherently social and collective; 2) knowledge/knowing is always highly contextual; 3) singular forms of knowledge/knowing are insufficient for informing complex, holistic practices like social work; 4) different knowledges/ways of knowing are equally valid in particular contexts; and 5) knowledge is made, not discovered" (p. 232).

These assumptions clearly do not underpin the traditional approaches to research and theory, instead this notion of praxis rejects ideas of objective, non-biased, neutral research and practice of which many incoming students and students that continue on the periphery of social work research, consider "science" and "scientific." For the purposes of this article and our approach to facilitating this research course, praxis emphasises the importance of using research and theory for emancipatory purposes, and reflecting on whose interests are served by current theory and research. Similarly, critically reflecting on practice ensuring that practice contributes to how we understand theory and the context in which we operate.

Gifted by hindsight, we reflect on the experiences of teaching a mandatory, undergraduate research course for social work students on their journey to learning about qualitative research. Similar to the seminal work of Epstein (1987) our major data is also "a pile of course evaluations" that we utilized for course collaboration and shared class improvement over the semester. The Conjoint Faculties Research Ethics Board has reviewed and approved the use of anonymized course evaluation data (REB22-0259).

The How To's: Taking a Social Work Approach to Education

Theoretical frameworks in critical pedagogy, disability studies, trauma-informed and anti-oppressive education provide well-established approaches to structuring learning environments that foster relational, participatory, and ethical engagement. Scholars have demonstrated that education is never a neutral act but one that either reinforces or challenges existing power structures (Freire, 2000; Gaudry & Lorenz, 2018; Hill Collins, 2002; hooks, 1994; Sins Invalid, 2019; L. T. Smith, 2021).

Black feminist thought, disability justice, and decolonial scholarship have each contributed to a deeper understanding of how knowledge is produced, who is included in the learning process, and how educational spaces can be sites of liberation or exclusion. These perspectives emphasize that students bring knowledge, experience, and ways of knowing that should be integrated into the learning process rather than dismissed in favour of dominant academic traditions.

Cultural wealth frameworks further this argument by positioning students' experiences not as deficits to be corrected but as valuable sources of knowledge (Maglalang & Rao, 2021). This perspective challenges dominant narratives that frame academic knowledge as objective and separate from the realities of minoritized communities. Disability justice scholars have built on this critique by demonstrating how academic institutions privilege certain cognitive and communicative styles, discriminating against those who engage with knowledge in non-dominant ways. This challenges narrow definitions of participation, advocating for learning environments that accommodate multiple ways of engaging with research (Price, 2011; Titchkosky, 2011). Indigenous and decolonial approaches emphasize relational accountability, arguing that knowledge is not simply acquired but developed through reciprocal relationships within

communities (Simpson, 2014; L. T. Smith, 2021; Wilson, 2008). These perspectives highlight the need for research education that moves beyond individual achievement toward collective inquiry, reinforcing the Kapwa concepts that emphasize interdependence and shared responsibility in learning (Maglalang & Rao, 2021).

Despite the depth of scholarship in these areas, integrating these insights into social work research education remains challenging. Educators are tasked with covering extensive theoretical and methodological content while also ensuring students develop the necessary competencies for research practice. Institutional and administrative demands often restrict the time and flexibility needed to implement participatory and relational pedagogies. Research on teaching and learning suggests that when faced with high cognitive and professional demands, educators and students alike tend to default to familiar instructional models that prioritize content delivery over engagement (Ambrose et al., 2010; Lang, 2021). These constraints are not simply a matter of individual capacity but reflect broader systemic structures that shape how research education is designed and delivered.

Social work education is relational, but structural conditions often make it difficult to sustain pedagogical approaches that centre engagement, care, and accessibility. Compa Love (Maglalang & Rao, 2021) emphasizes that curiosity and connection are essential components of learning rather than distractions from research training. Research education that prioritizes relational engagement fosters critical inquiry, enabling students to see research as a process of meaning-making rather than an abstract or detached exercise. As mentioned above, Kapwa reinforces the idea that knowledge production is a collective act rather than an individual pursuit, aligning with social work's commitment to community-based and participatory approaches to research.

While these theoretical insights provide a foundation for reimagining research education, their implementation can feel overwhelming, given the multiple demands placed on educators. As such, we have distilled many core ideas to offer a starting point for integrating relational, participatory, and strengths-based approaches into social work research education. This does not require educators to undertake a complete pedagogical transformation but provides an entry point for making intentional shifts that align with the relational and ethical commitments of social work. Research on critical pedagogy emphasizes that meaningful change in education occurs through iterative practice rather than immediate or totalizing reform. By embedding these principles into research education, instructors can create learning environments that foster engagement, critical inquiry, and professional accountability while ensuring that research is not separate from the relational values that define social work practice.

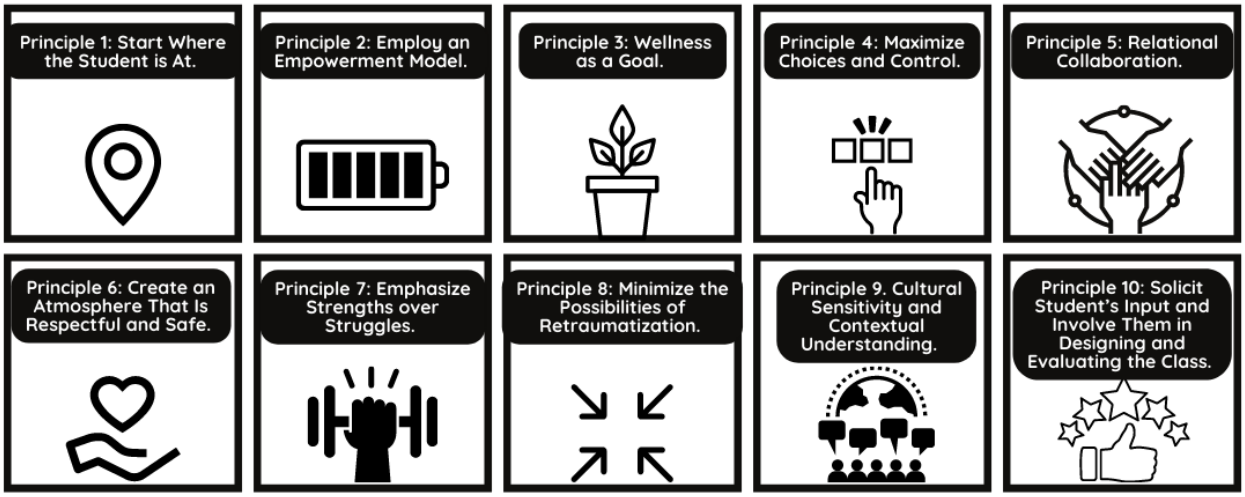
Many of these frameworks are inherently trauma-informed and anti-oppressive, recognizing that structural violence, exclusion, and systemic inequities shape knowledge engagement, creation and the learning environment. Reflecting on our own experiences and drawing from these theories, we grounded our principles in these approaches, recognizing that research education must account for the structural, emotional, and cognitive stresses that impact students and educators alike. Trauma-informed stresses the importance of acknowledging and understanding the significant neurological, biological, psychological, spiritual, and social effects of trauma and violence, and reframes maladaptive behaviours, such as anxiety, self-harm, suicide, substance abuse, anger, aggression, and mistrust as coping strategies common among those who have been exposed to traumatic events (Elliott et al., 2005; Gilin & Kauffman, 2015; Sanders, 2021).

Moreover, we quite like the definition of anti-oppressive practice used by Amadasun and Omorogiuwa (2020),

> At the most basic level, it aims to analyze how power is used to oppress and marginalize people and how such power can be equally used to fast-track the liberation and empowerment of people across a broad spectrum of social settings, relations or systems (p.199).

From there**,** we developed our ten principles for Social Work Research Education (Figure 1) and followed them throughout the semester.

Figure 1
Ten Principles for Social Work Research Education



Principle 1: Start Where the Student is At

An old adage, we realize, but useful all the same. This included recognizing the long-term and pervasive impacts of violence and victimization, discrimination and oppression. Noting that these would not be isolated events; rather, they would have ripple effects on identity, relationships, expectations of self and others, ability to regulate emotions, and view of the world. Unrau & Grinnell (2005) found that student anxiety about research-related topics appears to be an issue that goes deeper than students' self-perceptions. Social work students have genuine fears and reluctance about social work research which need to be addressed before they can have positive beliefs about social work research (Gibbs & Stirling, 2010); and that social work research can be viewed as integrated aspect of social work practice not outside their reach or wheel-house.

We got to know the students personally and their goals for the course and beyond the course, asking them their prior experiences of research, if any, their views of research, its relevance to social work and what they thought research was generally, and then what they thought social work research was specifically. As this class was online due to the COVID-19 pandemic, social work students were asked to make a recording answering questions such as, what does research mean to you? How might you apply research to being social worker? What is your career goal? What would you like to achieve through this course? By starting with students' perceptions,

understandings, goals, and values we were able to shift the course to meet their pace. Also, by affording students the opportunity to view each other's videos and provide their thoughts and reflections on the online discussion board, there was a rapid realization that many students shared collective sentiments, fears and worries.

Principle 2: Employ an Empowerment Model

An empowerment model incorporates those elements of a helping relationship that can increase the student's power in personal, interpersonal, and political spheres. The empowerment model is essential in a trauma-informed approach to recognize the individuals' strengths and capacities students do have.

The introductory videos facilitated the opportunity to build an empowerment model, learning more about students what they liked about school, what they enjoyed, and what they found fun. We collectively reframed those core skills back to research, specifically to qualitative research and other ways of knowing. This allowed students the opportunity to realize they had "research tools" in their toolkits already, despite not recognizing them as such.

This was further reinforced by a full class activity to define a research question based in practical social work-related issues. Understanding core goals for students were to build their resumes, the presentations were turned into a "lighting talk" format where presenters could add this experience to their academic CV. A basic principle of adult education is that adult learners are most receptive to learning those things that they have identified as necessary to gain mastery in the job which they currently hold or to which they aspire (Knowles, 1972).

Principle 3: Wellness as a Goal

Epstein (1987) recommends openly acknowledging student resistance to research. Inviting open, honest discussions at the start of the course, addressing negative attitudes towards research and personal fears and anxieties about its mastery. In turn, the instructor must be able to empathize with these concerns but communicate confidence that students will master the material. Reminding students that "research" is not synonymous with math or statistics, though it may in some paradigms make use of its concepts.

Aligned with anti-oppressive approach, we recognized our roles in perpetuating certain fears, especially for minoritized individuals, given that marks are the currency of institutions that lead to better life outcomes, but are at crossroads with learning, trying, and potentially failing.

As such, we intentionally focused on student wellness, both verbally and through anonymous surveys—recognizing that healthier students would grasp knowledge more effectively. We provided time *in class* to meet in groups and to work on individual assignments with the support of the instructor and TA. This allowed for more opportunities to work through problems and "get it wrong" without consequence. Moreover, this supported individuals with obligations to employment and family outside of school hours reduce their burden and potential disadvantages.

Principle 4: Maximize Choices and Control

Work collaboratively with students to increase their access to conscious choice to provide a sense of control over important life decisions. It is only through this personal experience of

choice and control that individuals reclaims their right to direct their life and pursue personal goals and dreams.

The research course provided a series of guest lectures to discuss the full breadth of what research could look like from Indigenous research and ways of knowing, arts-based methods, participatory research methods and qualitative methodology. This variety of instructors also provided the opportunity for students to see how research could be utilized and the diversity of topics, methods and outputs. Additionally, we provided options around research articles, instead of prescribing them in advance. While the latter may have eased the marking load, the former allowed students to seek out information that sparked joy and passion, and direct relatedness to their career goals.

Principle 5: Relational Collaboration

Educators must be aware of the inherent power imbalance in the helper-helped relationship and do their best to flatten the hierarchy. The trauma of this "power over" experience for individuals is best healed in a very different type of relationship, one that is collaborative and empowering.

We enabled mini peer-review groups where individuals could learn from each other in a supported non-hierarchical environment with reduced pressure. We also believed that by placing individuals in groups, they would be able to rely upon each other and reduce the workload. We are unsure if this was due to COVID-19 and the online environment, however, individuals did not seem to like the groups when it came to assignments and preferred to have done the learning in small groups for discussion, but the assignments for submission individually.

Principle 6: Create an Atmosphere That Is Respectful and Safe

A feeling of safety is enhanced when instructors give clear information, are consistent and predictable, and provide clear boundaries and well-defined roles.

We provided clarity around instructions, offering additional time to go over unclear concepts and providing examples that communicated expectations for assignments. Each assignment built on the previous one, such that errors in understanding could be identified and clarified with students. This also looked like compassion and flexibility around deadlines and due dates providing students with the understanding of the time required to mark assignments and when items need to be submitted. Students were given the flexibility to work within their schedules without penalty or repercussions. Rather built on respect, care and understanding.

Principle 7: Emphasize Strengths over Struggles

The nature of academy and for high achievers is to focus so intently on the things that they did not get "right" at the expense of the things they did. While the students bemoaned assignments they were "small" in terms of the cumulative worth to the final grade. It provided opportunities for students to engage in a low-pressure environment and display their knowledge to date.

This included assignments looking at ethics, positionality, and providing peer-review to colleagues' presentations. They were able to fail miserably without much loss (and with a lot of learning) so that when they went into the things with the larger marks they benefitted from having already had the opportunity to identify gaps in their understandings. Through these micro-

assignments, students were provided tangible examples of their learning and in doing so, built confidence in their abilities.

Principle 8: Minimize the Possibilities of Retraumatization

Well-intended educators participate in a system that may be retraumatizing, especially for Indigenous and Black students. Education's actions may inadvertently parallel interpersonal dynamics that recall and exacerbate trauma responses.

We were intentional around regular self-reflection and weekly meetings to provide support and insight into interactions with students, to address the subjectivity of marking through blinded reviews and to recognize the value of marks in the broader academy. We provided intensive, concrete, and constructive feedback for students to learn, instead of arbitrary marks with a sense of powerlessness on how to improve, or at the mercy of an educator's whim.

Principle 9. Cultural Sensitivity and Contextual Understanding

Understanding the influence of someone's culture is essential to making an effective connection. This does not require that every educator have detailed knowledge of every culture, but rather that he or she recognize the importance of cultural context. It is often helpful to ask questions, be open to being educated, and try to understand the learner's experience and responses through the lens of their cultural context. Cultural context is not the only difference that is important. Sexual orientation, religion, age, economic class, disability status, race, ethnicity, and other characteristics all interact to create more or less stigma, discrimination and oppression.

Practically, this included discussions of worldview, ensuring correct pronunciations of names and pronouns and recognizing the impacts of social locatedness through facilitated group discussions.

Principle 10: Solicit Student's Input and Involve Them in Designing and Evaluating the Class

Students should be involved in designing the course and be part of an ongoing evaluation. We conducted optional anonymous surveys which students were provided class time to fill out in order to provide students with multiple opportunities to improve their in-class experience. Details were shared openly with the class so they could see how their suggestions shaped the class direction and they created their own growth and personal metrics around "success" that they measured themselves against throughout the class.

Students' Reflections

At the end of the semester, students provided optional reflections about the course in class, and anonymously online, we have included some example reflections to illustrate the students' growth and experiences throughout the course:

> I was scared of it, to be honest, but [the instructor] makes research approachable and interesting. She wants us to succeed in this class and it shows.

It is very exciting that I could potentially do my own research one day and find out the answers to some the questions that may come up in my practice.

I am most surprised that I am enjoying learning about research more than I thought I would. It has enlightened me to how beneficial it is to the field of social work, in particular social justice.

When starting this class, I was seriously considering research as my primary career path, but I was pretty confident that once I learned about true, real research, that it would scare me off. But I've found the opposite! This class has made me feel more competent, more interested and even more excited to pursue research. This is a huge relief to me, and very exciting!

This class went much better than my expectations. I did not expect to enjoy it and I thought I was not interested in research.

This class exceeded my expectations, I was expecting to hate research, but I actually enjoyed this class. I was terrified of taking this class and I don't think I would have done so well if it wasn't for the professor and TA. I felt like I could go to them with any problem I was having and it would be okay.

Building Research Confidence: Implications and Next Steps

Social work is a relational discipline, yet research education often prioritizes content over connection. The ten principles outlined in this manuscript provide a foundation for structuring research courses in ways that align with the values of social work practice. This approach does not replace theoretical and methodological instruction but enhances student engagement and knowledge retention by integrating pedagogical strategies that foster reflection, critical inquiry, and applied learning. Research courses offer an opportunity to teach not only the technical aspects of research but also the process of inquiry, reinforcing the profession's commitment to ethical engagement, responsiveness, and social change.

A significant challenge in research education is the expectation to cover extensive theoretical and methodological content within limited instructional time. Research on learning demonstrates that students retain information more effectively when they actively engage with course material rather than passively receive information (Ambrose et al., 2010; Lang, 2021). The structure of research education should incorporate opportunities for applied engagement rather than rely solely on content transmission. Creating space for students to reflect on their relationship to research, apply theoretical concepts to real-world contexts, and collaborate in knowledge production enhances comprehension and motivation. Research courses should be designed not as a series of discrete topics but as an iterative process that builds research confidence and critical analysis skills.

The need for a more engaged and responsive approach to research education extends beyond social work. While this manuscript focuses on social work classrooms, the challenges outlined are not unique to the discipline. Many educators across faculties experience increasing demands, reduced instructional time, and the pressures of content-heavy curricula. Social work educators may already integrate relational and participatory approaches implicitly, given the

profession's focus on engagement and reflexivity. However, in disciplines where these pedagogical foundations are not as embedded, students may benefit even more from intentional efforts to structure research education to enhance confidence, relevance, and meaningful application. These insights have broad implications for strengthening research capacity in professional programs where students are expected to translate research knowledge into practice.

Integrating these approaches requires rethinking how student engagement is measured. Assessments should reflect not only comprehension of research methods but also students' ability to apply them critically and confidently. Research on high-impact learning emphasizes that students who feel a sense of agency in their learning process are more likely to retain and apply knowledge effectively (Ambrose et al., 2010). Expanding assessment approaches to include self-reflection, qualitative evaluation of engagement, and applied research projects aligns learning outcomes with the profession's emphasis on practice-based knowledge.

The ten principles outlined in this manuscript provide a structured and adaptable framework for research education that supports both academic and professional competencies. They offer an *entry point* for educators seeking to integrate relational, participatory, and strengths-based approaches into research instruction. Future curriculum development should explore ways to integrate pedagogical strategies that enhance student engagement while maintaining the rigour and depth required for effective research training. Research education should not be an isolated or technical exercise but a process that prepares students to engage critically, confidently and, most importantly, joyfully with knowledge. By embedding these principles into research education, instructors create learning environments that support inquiry, accountability, and research confidence.

Our Final Reflections

The potential for social work students to become qualitative researchers (with big 'R' or small 'r') can be undermined by the split between research and practice (Lewis, 2003; Newman & McNamara, 2016), where one is favoured over the other, not fully recognizing the integration between the two. Social workers have numerous and varied practical skills that translate to the research process which are often disregarded. For example, working with clients and families and working with study participants and data. Moreover, ideas which emerged from the practice, such as emancipatory or critical ways of social working easily become ethically sound and transformative research tools.

We echo Lewis's (2013) sentiments that the value of engaging in research activities should not be limited to the acquisition of research skills, or simply as a means to an end for a tenure-track academic position. Rather, it is also an intensely personal journey, which, if embraced, may lead to radical change for the individual and the profession. It is our strong belief, based on our and our undergraduate students' experiences, that all those involved in social work should have access to these opportunities to contribute to and advance a well-informed profession.

Conclusion

Transforming social work research education requires moving beyond the traditional divide between research and practice. This manuscript has outlined a structured approach that prioritizes relational, participatory, and strengths-based pedagogy, ensuring that research is not perceived as abstract, inaccessible, or disconnected from social work's core values. By embedding

research within a framework that acknowledges students' lived experiences, professional aspirations, and learning anxieties, educators can foster a deeper engagement with research as both a process and a tool for social change.

The principles outlined in this paper are not intended as a rigid or prescriptive model but rather as an entry point for reflection and action. The demands placed on educators are considerable, and structural constraints often limit the extent to which pedagogical change can occur. However, small, intentional shifts in how research is taught, such as emphasizing student agency, integrating applied learning opportunities, and fostering a classroom environment that encourages curiosity, can have a meaningful impact on students' confidence and competence in research.

While this work is grounded in social work education, its relevance extends beyond a single discipline. The tensions described here between content coverage and student engagement, between theoretical knowledge and applied learning, between institutional constraints and pedagogical aspirations are not unique to social work. The principles outlined offer insights that may be valuable to educators in other fields who face similar challenges in fostering meaningful and lasting engagement with research.

The goal of research education should not simply be to impart methodological knowledge but to cultivate a mindset in which research is seen as an essential, dynamic, and integral part of professional practice. By embedding relational and applied learning strategies into research education, educators can ensure that students graduate not only with research literacy but with the confidence and curiosity to apply research in ways that enhance their practice, their professions, and the communities they serve.

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